

Udon noodles with seitan, broccoli, and napa cabbage

Thick udon noodles nearly melt in your mouth. When they are matched with a salty, savory sauce, I find them **addictive**. Look for fresh refrigerated noodles in your local Asian specialty shop. Boiling them just before adding them to the wok or frying pan will break them up and make them easier to handle. This dish makes a beautiful presentation and is a full meal on its own.

¼ ounce dried shiitake mushrooms [7g]

2 tablespoons peanut oil

10 dried small red chiles (1 to 3 broken open)

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 piece of ginger, 1 inch [2.5cm], thinly sliced into matchsticks

1 medium onion, thinly sliced

½ recipe cooked Dark Meat Seitan (page 234) or Savory Seitan Roast (page 236; omit sauce), thinly sliced

1½ cups napa cabbage, shredded [375ml]

1 medium carrot, shredded

1 pound fresh udon noodles [500g]

1½ cups cooked broccoli florets [80g]

1½ tablespoons toasted sesame oil

1 tablespoon black bean sauce

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

1 teaspoon soy sauce

¾ to 1 cup bamboo shoots, thinly sliced

1 tablespoon rice wine vinegar

2 teaspoons fresh lime juice

Salt

1 handful of fresh bean sprouts

1 to 2 tablespoons shredded nori*

2 tablespoons black and white sesame seeds

Lime wedges, for garnish

*You can buy sheets of nori sea vegetable and toast and cut them yourself, or you can save yourself a lot of time and buy them already toasted and shredded. You will likely find this product in your Asian or Chinese specialty store.

1. Bring a large pot of water to a boil. You will **drop** your noodles in just before adding them to your wok or pan in Step 5.
2. In a medium heatproof bowl, **soak** the mushrooms in hot water to cover until soft, about 15 minutes. Lift out the mushrooms and squeeze excess liquid back into the bowl. Strain the soaking liquid through a coffee filter or double thickness of dampened cheesecloth and reserve.
3. Heat the peanut oil in a wok or large frying pan over high heat. Add the chiles, garlic, and ginger. **Cook**, stirring constantly, for 30 seconds, or until the garlic is fragrant but not brown. Add the onion and cook until softened and lightly browned, 2 to 3 minutes.
4. **Add** the seitan and cook for a minute or so. If the ingredients begin to stick at this point, add a couple of tablespoons of the reserved mushroom soaking liquid.
5. Reduce the heat slightly. Add the cabbage and carrot and cook until the cabbage wilts, about 1 minute. At the same time, add the udon noodles to the boiling water and cook for 30 seconds, or until heated through and separated. **Drain** and add to the wok. Add the broccoli and stir well. Stir in the sesame oil, black bean sauce, sugar, soy sauce, and bamboo shoots.
6. Remove from the heat. **Stir** in the vinegar and lime juice and season with salt to taste. Serve the noodles hot, topping each portion with bean sprouts, nori, and sesame seeds. Garnish the plates with a lime wedge.

SERVES 6

tip Blanch your broccoli for about 1 minute in the same boiling water you are using to cook the udon noodles. Cool under cold water and set aside until ready to add to the wok.